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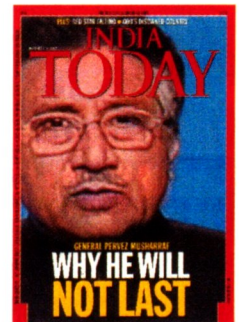
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Dictators have one common flaw: they are so blinded by power that they fail to read the writing on the wall. Pakistan's President Pervez Musharraf is no exception. The result of last week's general elections shows how much the popular mood had turned against him and yet he clearly ignored the warning signs. Even for us at INDIA TODAY, the writing has been on our wall. Our September 17, 2007, cover on Musharraf carried the headline: "Time Up?" That was when his popularity was plummeting and pressure from political rivals was on the rise. We put him again on our November 19 cover with the headline "Why He Will Not Last", following the state of Emergency he had imposed to save his skin. That was also the 16th time we had put him on our cover in the last eight years, a testament to the fascination with which the Indian public followed every move of the General.

Though his fate will be known soon, as will the question of who the next prime minister will be, the electoral verdict is a clear rejection of Musharraf and his King's party and a huge vote for change. That could see a tectonic shift in the power structure that would significantly impact the future of Pakistan, India and the world. This is also Pakistan's first taste of real democracy after the 1997 polls. Our cover story examines the prospects of the winning parties like the PPP, PML(Nawaz) and the Awami National Party working out a common agenda and providing a stable coalition. Their biggest challenge will be to find ways of diluting Musharraf's power or even oust him.



Our November '07 issue

He has amended the Constitution to give the President the power to dissolve Parliament and dismiss the prime minister. Also defacto he has the final say in foreign policy and national security. The new coalition would have to work together to make the Parliament and the prime minister supreme again.

Managing Editor Raj Chengappa travelled to Pakistan where he tied up with our regular contributor Hasan Zaidi and interviewed the main players in the ongoing drama, the duo who now hold the future of Pakistan in their hands—Asif Zardari, husband of the late Benazir Bhutto, and former prime minister Nawaz Sharif. Both are back from exile over corruption charges. As Chengappa says: "It's important that they not go back to the old ways of corruption and cronyism. This would give the army an excuse to interfere again."

For India, the return to democracy in Pakistan is welcome. Both PPP and PML(Nawaz) are for good relations with India. Indeed, for both the countries, the election results are the best news coming out of Pakistan in recent times. On the streets of Pakistan, there is suddenly new hope and confidence among the people. In India, there is also the hope that if Pakistan returns to the mainstream, it is the best possible development for us, and the rest of the world.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)